

Federation: Coastal Together Federation

Date: 15/03/23

Report: visit report

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Report details

Onsite visits took place on the 15th March 2023. This was arranged to complete a physical audit of 5 Coastal Federation schools.

Schools visited were:

- Freethorpe
- Cantly
- Horning
- Mundesley Infant
- Mundesley Junior
- Bacton

School audit visit feedback

Each school visited exhibited good data protection practices and it was rewarding as consultants to observe how the federation and schools had already advanced in their use of Cloud based solutions for processing, sharing and storing school data securely. For example: CPOMS for Safeguarding and cloud-based solutions, rather than physical data and folders. Servers are therefore being phased out. The federation has also banned the use of memory sticks.

Where paper records still exist there was mostly satisfactory physical security in place.

Speaking to staff it was evident that staff had been raising awareness and putting in place risk mitigations; Freethorpe had obscured the office window to reduce the risk of monitors being observed from the window and staff spoken to had good end of day routines to add files to secure cabinets. Photocopiers had secure codes and forenames only were predominantly used for lists and displays with corridors having photos without names.

Not all recommendations made are relevant to all schools. For best practice it is still worth communicating the summarised findings to all schools to check against, so that everyone is aware. The following documents on the DPE website can be used as reference documents:

- [DPE consent guidance](#)
- [DPE quick reference guide](#)
- [Records management best practice area](#)

Audit walk observations and recommendations:

Visitor sign in

Electronic systems of sign-in were used although not all had visitor statements available. Some schools requested ID, others did not.

Recommendations: Add the following statement to the electronic sign in systems: Visitor information is collected for health and safety, record of official visits and safeguarding. If you would like to know more, the general/visitors privacy notice is available on the school website, or you can ask at reception for a paper copy.

Ensure a consistent policy on ID checks.

Front/reception office/offices

Generally good practice with paper records secure and shredders/confidential waste bins in use, however at Bacton this was not the case with a confidential waste bag open in the office. This location also had a shredder available which may be a preferable alternative. At Horning, unshredded behaviour files were observed on top of the shredder.

Freethorpe office: Lack of secure storage. Although the door is locked at night there were sensitive files that ideally should be placed in a secure cabinet. Information observed: medical, PP, FSM and staff personnel/absence data.

Recommendation: Obtain a suitable secure cabinet for sensitive folders/data.

Bacton and Horning offices: Confidential waste.

Recommendation: Reminder to staff to ensure confidential waste bags are kept secure and no sensitive data is left on shredders.

Mundesley Infant Senco/Head of School office: unlocked. SEMH building: Staff ID left on desk.

Recommendation: SLT offices should be locked when unattended. Staff should always have their ID on their person.

Mundesley Junior SLT office: unlocked and information for Ofsted was left on the desk, including a full pupil list with SEN data. Sets of keys left unattended.

Recommendation: Keep files and offices secure. Keys should be kept in key safes and signed in/out to ensure correct physical access controls.

Servers

Recommendation: Freethorpe had a server in the classroom. Although servers are being phased out it is recommended that the data still accessed on the server is reviewed and the recent NCC thematic audit is revisited (i.e. servers kept secure).

iPads

Freethorpe: 1 x iPad without secure code access. All other iPads checked did have secure codes to access.

Recommendations: Add secure code to iPad and complete checks across the federation.

Classrooms

Bacton pre-school: Noticeboard used as a filing system. Information included new children starting and consent to observe notes.

Recommendations: Keep data securely in its proper file location.

Classroom fire lists: Firelists are required when students have to be evacuated and full name is used in the majority of cases.

Recommendation: Although risks are minimal, consider adding a cover sheet and heading (Firelist) to the firelist sheet/clipboards. This will also improve the process when supply staff are used as the firelist sheet will be labelled appropriately.

Classroom folders: Most information is now kept online although some folders with sensitive information were observed..

Recommendation: For physical folders still remaining in classrooms that contain sensitive data the schools can check the process for storing securely and check if these are still needed. 1 x SEND folder in Y3 observed - Freethorpe (Mandy) to check the process including the process for care plans.

Coat pegs and student trays: Some coat pegs and trays had a photo and forename.

Recommendations: Where there is a teaching and learning justification (learning names at reception) and the area is a controlled space this is acceptable and should be assessed by school and area. Consent guidance documentation can also be referenced against.

Medical files on display

It is noted that at some settings, medical information is pinned to the staffroom and/or medical room wall. Some attempts to protect this data from casual observation have been made by covering up specifics.

Recommendation: It is unlikely that staff refer to this document in this location either casually or in an emergency. Whilst we agree that the information is vitally important, we recommend changing from a passive "information available" approach, to a pro-active "informing" approach. This allows you to put proper protections of the data in place (secure it), whilst making sure that staff who need to know the information, do indeed actually know it.

Accident books

Mundesley Junior: Minor accidents/incidents - details kept in a single book in a cart.

Recommendation: Minimise the history available in a book. e.g use one slip per incident and post to a secure "letterbox" to be cleared daily.

Locking of computers

Recommendations: There were locations where the hall computer and display were still logged in. At Bacton, this allowed an account and access to email via the browser. Users may not be aware that other users' Google account was accessible via their logging into the Chrome browser.

Remind staff to use **Windows key + L** to lock laptops/desktops when not in the work area.

Physical security

Recommendation: Keep offices locked when not in use.

Follow up actions:

- Action recommendations from the audit walk findings.
- Disseminate the federations retention schedule to staff and use it as a working document.
- Review consent forms, guidance, procedures and processes, especially in preparation for the new intake.
- Ensure all staff have completed GDPR and Stay Safe Online NCSC training and if not already, incorporate as part of the induction process with new staff.
- Continue to raise awareness across the federation.